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The future trajectory of BRICS

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What potential does BRICS have and what are its future prospects? Can it really emerge as a collective that will reject the current neoliberal order and seek to promote a much more social welfarist form of capitalist development that might at least unleash a dynamic much more conducive to the emergence of more progressive social and political forces whose pressures from below can then take a more radical anti-capitalist direction? Will it seriously challenge the existing world order where the imperialist behaviour of the US continues to be highly, sometimes decisively influential in shaping the course of events? Or are these governments headed by elites whose principal preoccupation is forging a more cooperative system of global management of a world capitalist order in which their voices will be more seriously listened to and in which their own ranking in the global pecking order of elites rises much more significantly?

In this regard there have been two contesting views. One has been marked by considerable enthusiasm about its potential. The very fact of regular summit meetings with an 'escalating consensus' is thought to bode well for the body's future and its ability to reshape the institutions and practices of global governance. The fact that the G7 gave way to the G8 which in turn has now given way to the G20 (incorporating the BRICS countries as well as other emerging economies) as the main international grouping undertaking to steer the world economy, is taken as testimony of the growing relevance of the emerging powers in general, and BRICS in particular. Others are more sceptical. Here, the BRICS countries are viewed not so much as major reformers of the current global neoliberal order but as new members happily included in a still hierarchical